

Shoulder Arthritis Exercises: A Complete UK Physiotherapy Guide

UK physiotherapist-approved exercises for shoulder arthritis. Step-by-step strengthening, range-of-motion and stretching exercises to reduce pain and improve mobility.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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*Person performing gentle shoulder stretching exercises at home for arthritis physiotherapy
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Shoulder arthritis affects approximately **one in three people over 60** in the UK to some degree, making it one of the most common causes of shoulder pain and

restricted movement. Whether you have osteoarthritis, rheumatoid arthritis or post-traumatic arthritis of the shoulder, targeted exercises can significantly reduce pain, improve range of motion and help you maintain independence for daily tasks like dressing, reaching and driving. This guide provides UK physiotherapist-approved exercises specifically designed for shoulder arthritis.

Understanding Shoulder Arthritis

The shoulder is the most mobile joint in the body, with an extraordinary range of motion that allows you to reach, lift, throw and rotate your arm in almost any direction. This mobility comes at a cost — the shoulder relies heavily on muscles, tendons and ligaments for stability rather than bony architecture, making it vulnerable to wear, injury and arthritis.

There are two joints in the shoulder complex that can be affected by arthritis: the **glenohumeral joint** (the main ball-and-socket joint where the upper arm meets the shoulder blade) and the **acromioclavicular (AC) joint** (where the collarbone meets the top of the shoulder blade). AC joint arthritis is particularly common and often causes pain when reaching across the body or overhead.

Symptoms of Shoulder Arthritis

- Deep, aching pain in the shoulder joint, often worse at night
 - Stiffness, particularly in the morning or after periods of inactivity
 - Reduced range of motion — difficulty reaching behind your back, overhead or across your body
 - Grinding, clicking or crepitus during movement
 - Pain with activities like dressing, washing hair, reaching shelves or driving
 - Weakness in the affected arm
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Before You Start: Important Guidelines



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- Warm up first — apply a warm flannel or heat pack to the shoulder for 10 minutes before exercising
- Move gently — never force a painful movement. Work within your comfortable range
- Consistency beats intensity — daily gentle exercise is better than occasional vigorous sessions
- Pain monitoring — mild discomfort during exercise is acceptable, but sharp or worsening pain means stop
- If pain persists more than 2 hours after exercising, you've done too much — reduce intensity next time
- Consult your GP or physiotherapist before starting if you've had recent shoulder surgery or injection

Range-of-Motion Exercises

These exercises aim to maintain or improve the movement available in your shoulder joint. Perform each exercise 5–10 times, twice daily.

1. Pendulum Swings

Lean forward with your good hand on a table for support. Let the affected arm hang freely. Gently swing the arm in small circles — clockwise for 30 seconds, then anticlockwise for 30 seconds. Gradually increase the circle size as comfort allows. You can hold a small tin of beans (400g) to add gentle traction. This exercise uses gravity to decompress the joint and is excellent for warming up.

2. Wall Crawl (Forward)

Stand facing a wall at arm's length. Place the fingertips of your affected hand on the wall at waist height. Slowly "crawl" your fingers up the wall as high as comfortable. Hold at the top for 5 seconds, then crawl back down. Mark your progress with a small piece of tape — this gives you a visual target to work towards over weeks.

3. Wall Crawl (Side)

Stand sideways to the wall with your affected shoulder closest. Repeat the crawling motion out to the side. This targets a different plane of movement (abduction) that is often restricted in shoulder arthritis.

4. Behind-the-Back Reach

Hold a towel behind your back with both hands — the good arm reaches over the shoulder, the affected arm reaches up from below. Gently pull upward with the good arm to guide the affected arm into a stretch. Hold for 10–15 seconds. This mimics the movement needed for fastening a bra, tucking in a shirt or reaching a back pocket.

5. Cross-Body Stretch

Use your good arm to gently pull the affected arm across your body at chest height. You should feel a stretch at the back and side of the shoulder. Hold for 15–20 seconds. This targets the posterior capsule, which often tightens in shoulder arthritis.

Strengthening Exercises



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Once range of motion improves, gentle strengthening helps support and protect the joint. Use light resistance bands (available from pharmacies and online, £5–£15) or small weights (0.5–1 kg to start).

1. Isometric External Rotation

Stand sideways to a wall with the affected arm closest. Bend your elbow to 90 degrees and place the back of your hand against the wall. Push gently into the wall (as if trying to rotate your arm outward) and hold for 10 seconds. This strengthens the rotator cuff without moving the painful joint. Repeat 10 times.

2. Resistance Band External Rotation

Anchor a resistance band at elbow height (a door handle works well). Hold the band with the affected arm, elbow bent to 90 degrees and tucked into your side. Rotate your forearm outward against the band's resistance, then slowly return. Keep the elbow glued to your side

throughout. Perform 2 sets of 10 repetitions.

3. Shoulder Blade Squeezes

Sit or stand with good posture. Squeeze your shoulder blades together as if trying to hold a pencil between them. Hold for 5 seconds, then relax. This strengthens the muscles that stabilise the shoulder blade, providing a better foundation for shoulder movement. Repeat 15 times.

4. Wall Press-Up

Stand an arm's length from a wall, hands at shoulder height. Slowly bend your elbows to lean towards the wall, then push back. This gently strengthens the chest and front shoulder muscles. Perform 2 sets of 10 repetitions. Progress by standing further from the wall.

Daily Activities and Adaptations

- Dressing — Put the affected arm into sleeves first; use front-fastening clothes; try a dressing stick or long-handled shoe horn
 - Reaching — Use a grabber/reacher for high shelves; reorganise cupboards to keep frequently used items at waist to shoulder height
 - Sleeping — Try sleeping on your back with a pillow under the affected arm, or on the unaffected side with a pillow hugging the affected arm
 - Driving — Adjust your seat and mirrors to minimise reaching; consider a steering wheel cover for easier grip
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When to Seek Further Help

See your GP if shoulder pain is severe or worsening despite exercises, you have sudden inability to lift your arm (possible rotator cuff tear), you experience numbness or tingling down the arm, or shoulder pain is disrupting sleep consistently. Your GP can refer you to NHS physiotherapy (typically 4–8 weeks wait) or an orthopaedic specialist if needed. Treatments may include corticosteroid injections, hyaluronic acid injections or, in severe cases, shoulder replacement surgery.

Consistent, gentle exercise is the single most effective long-term treatment for shoulder arthritis. Start slowly, be patient with progress and celebrate small improvements. Our virtual

assistant can help you create a personalised shoulder exercise programme.

This article is for general information only. Consult a physiotherapist or GP before starting exercises if you have severe shoulder pain or have had recent surgery.

Shoulder Exercises for Osteoarthritis

For shoulder (glenohumeral) osteoarthritis, the priority is restoring pain-free range of motion before adding load. Pendulum swings, wall slides and supine external rotation with a light band are the safest starting points. See our osteoarthritis exercises guide and osteoarthritis treatment overview.

Shoulder Exercises for Rheumatoid Arthritis

Shoulder RA responds best to a low-load, high-repetition approach. During flares, restrict to pendulums and supported range of motion only. Resume strengthening when the joint is no longer warm. See rheumatoid arthritis exercises.

Gentle Shoulder Exercises for Severe Arthritis

Pendulum swings, supported table slides, gentle scapular squeezes and warm-water exercise allow you to keep the shoulder moving without overloading the joint. Two short 10-minute daily sessions are usually better tolerated than one longer one.

Shoulder Exercises After Replacement

After shoulder replacement (anatomic or reverse), follow your surgeon's protocol precisely for the first 6–12 weeks. The strengthening routine on this page typically becomes appropriate beyond 12 weeks, once cleared by your surgical team.

Exercises to Avoid With Shoulder Arthritis

Avoid behind-the-neck lat pulldowns, military presses, upright rows, heavy bench press and any overhead lifting with poor technique. Replace with band external rotation, wall push-ups and seated rows. For a personalised plan, find a shoulder physiotherapist near you.

Shoulder Arthritis Exercise FAQ — People Also Ask

What are the best exercises for arthritic shoulders?

The best routine combines pendulum swings and wall slides (mobility), band external rotation and scapular squeezes (strength), and warm-up with a heat pack for 10 minutes. Done 3–4 times per week, this combination reduces pain and improves overhead reach.

How often should I do shoulder exercises for arthritis?

Mobility daily (5–10 minutes), strengthening 2–3 times per week. Allow at least one rest day between strengthening sessions.

Can exercise cure shoulder arthritis?

No — exercise cannot reverse cartilage loss, but it is the most effective non-surgical treatment and can delay the need for shoulder replacement. Benefits stop if exercise stops.

What shoulder exercises should I avoid with arthritis?

Avoid behind-the-neck lat pulldowns, military presses, upright rows and heavy overhead lifting. Replace with band external rotation, wall push-ups and seated rows.

Are there gentle shoulder exercises for severe arthritis?

Yes — pendulum swings, supported table slides, scapular squeezes and warm-water exercise. Two short 10-minute daily sessions are usually better tolerated.

How long until shoulder exercises reduce arthritis pain?

Reduced stiffness within 2–3 weeks, meaningful pain reduction at 6–8 weeks, full benefit at 12 weeks of consistent practice.

Related Shoulder & Arthritis Guides

- Osteoarthritis exercises — full programme
- Osteoarthritis treatment options (UK)
- Rheumatoid arthritis exercises
- More shoulder exercises for osteoarthritis
- Shoulder exercises for rheumatoid arthritis
- Anti-inflammatory diet for arthritis

- Find a shoulder physiotherapist near you
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Q&A

Question: What are the best exercises for arthritic shoulders?

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